

Redistributive Justice, Job Insecurity, and Perceived Technological Risk: How Labor Market Position Shapes the Legitimacy of the Welfare State in 27 OECD Countries

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Abstract

This study

Keywords: Redistributive preferences, Labor market position, Welfare State

1 Introduction

Contemporary technological transformations, such as automation, artificial intelligence, algorithmic management and intermediation through digital platforms, are altering the conditions under which workers relate to social protection systems, the subjective experience of their position in the labour market and, with it, their assessment of the justice of their relationship with the welfare state ([Busemeyer and Sahm, 2022](#); [Frey and Osborne, 2017](#); [Gallego and Kurer, 2022](#); [Vallas and Schor, 2020](#)). These systems were built on the premise of stable, full-time and long-term employment, in which contributions flowed predictably from wages and rights accumulated over continuous careers ([Esping-Andersen, 1993](#); [Korpi and Palme, 1998](#)). The progressive decoupling between that model and the actual forms of work, mainly through temporary contracts, self-employment and platform-mediated work, raises the question of how citizens today perceive the justice of the exchange they maintain with the institutions that ought to protect them. In Europe, this question has also entered the policy agenda: access to social protection for self-employed and platform workers has been the object of a Council Recommendation ([Council of the European Union, 2019](#)) and, more recently, of a directive on improving working conditions in platform work ([European Parliament and Council of the European Union, 2024](#)).

Research on attitudes towards the welfare state has examined extensively the determinants of support for redistribution, showing that exposure to labour market risk and to automation tends to increase the demand for social protection ([Busemeyer and Sahm, 2022](#); [Rehm, 2009](#); [Thewissen and Rueda, 2019](#)). Much less attention has been paid, by contrast, to perceived redistributive justice, that is, to the evaluative judgement of whether the benefits that an individual receives from the state constitute just compensation for the taxes and contributions they pay ([Roosma et al., 2016](#)).

This study addresses whether perceiving the functioning of the state as just is related to labour market

position and the perception of technological risk. Drawing on data from the Risks That Matter survey of the OECD (2024), which covers more than 40,000 people in 27 countries, most of them European, this research places European welfare states in comparative perspective and simultaneously introduces three little-explored elements. First, it distinguishes labour market position according to type of employment—formal employees, self-employed workers and platform workers—, forms that maintain unequal links with the social protection system and that have rarely been examined together in relation to perceived redistributive justice. Second, it incorporates the perception of technological risk as a source of redistributive dissatisfaction distinct from type of employment and from conventional job insecurity, distinguishing its threatening dimension—the likelihood of being displaced by technology—from its enabling dimension—the perception that technology can improve working conditions—. Third, it incorporates the perceived deservingness of others—the judgement of whether others receive benefits from the state that they do not deserve—as a predictor of the assessment that each individual makes of their own relationship with the system (Van Oorschot, 2000, 2006).

The study makes three contributions. First, it extends comparative research on welfare attitudes by situating the structural conditions of the labour market as explanatory variables of perceived redistributive justice, linking subjective assessments of the welfare state with the organisation of work (Emmenegger et al., 2012; Kalleberg, 2011). Second, it provides comparative evidence on the effect of the perception of technological risk in an attitudinal domain distinct from the one that recent literature has concentrated on, concerned above all with support for redistribution or for social investment (Bussemeyer and Sahm, 2022; Thewissen and Rueda, 2019). Third, it places these processes within a comparative framework of welfare regimes, which makes it possible to assess how different institutional contexts moderate the relationship between labour market vulnerability, technological perception and judgements of justice (Esping-Andersen, 1993; Larsen, 2008), and speaks to the discussion on how welfare states should adapt social protection to employment forms that depart from the standard employment relationship.

The argument organising this work is that the perception of justice in the relationship between what one contributes and what one receives is not solely a function of ideological predispositions or of abstract beliefs about inequality, but is anchored in workers' everyday experience of the labour market: the employment relationship that links them to the protection system, how secure they feel in their jobs, whether they perceive technology as a threat or an opportunity, and how they judge the deservingness of those who also receive from the state. Although the welfare state was designed for a world of stable employment, its perceived legitimacy is called into question by labour markets that increasingly depart from that foundational assumption (Howcroft et al., 2025; Standing, 2014).

1.1 Redistributive justice as reciprocity

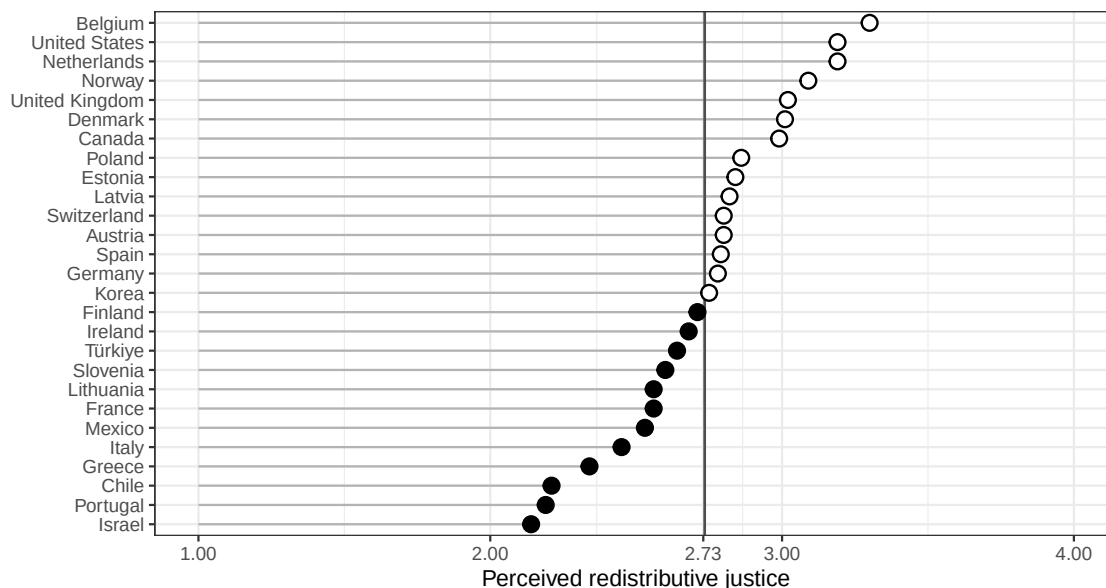
Research on attitudes towards the welfare state and inequality has distinguished between preferences -normative beliefs about how resources should be distributed- and perceptions -evaluative judgements about how the system actually works- (Castillo et al., 2022; McCall, 2013; Osberg and Smeeding, 2006). While the former have received greater attention, the latter have emerged as an object of study with distinct dynamics and consequences (Roosma et al., 2016; Svallfors, 2013). Perceived redistributive justice captures

whether individuals consider just the exchange they maintain with the welfare state when paying taxes and contributions in return for access to services and transfers. Its theoretical foundation lies in the logic of reciprocity, the principle according to which the legitimacy of the system rests not only on its redistributive outcomes, but on the perceived justice of the institutions that allocate contributions and benefits (Mau, 2014; Rothstein, 1998). When individuals feel that their contributions yield adequate returns, institutional trust is sustained; when the reciprocal logic is perceived to be broken (disproportionate contributions, insufficient benefits or a system that favours some over others), legitimacy is eroded (Cavaillé, 2025).

In recent decades, the study of redistributive attitudes has shown that, despite the sustained rise in inequality in most advanced democracies, there has been no proportional increase in the demand for redistribution (Cavaillé, 2025; Kenworthy and McCall, 2007; Mijs, 2021). Explanations of this apparent disconnect point to how citizens perceive inequality and their own position in the distribution (García-Castro et al., 2020; García-Sánchez et al., 2020; Gimpelson and Treisman, 2018), perceptions that interact with meritocratic beliefs to shape which type of distribution is considered just (Castillo et al., 2025). Within this framework, the perceived justice of the fiscal exchange occupies a particular place in that it does not measure how much redistribution a person wants, but rather judges whether the system treats them in a just way given what they contribute.

Comparative evidence shows that these perceptions vary systematically across countries (Blekesaune, 2003; Schmidt-Catran, 2016). Figure 1a presents the average of perceived redistributive justice in 27 countries and shows considerable heterogeneity, independently of welfare regime type.

Figure 1: Mean of perceived redistributive justice by OECD country



(a) Source: own elaboration with data from the OECD, Risks That Matter survey 2024. Perceived redistributive justice corresponds to the degree of agreement with the item on receiving a fair share of public benefits given the taxes and contributions paid (scale 1–5). The vertical grey line shows the OECD mean of redistributive justice.

1.2 Work, type of employment and platform economy

The sociology of work has documented in multiple contexts the growing polarisation between formal, well-paid employment and an expanding stratum of precarious work (Gallie, 2013; Kalleberg, 2011). Precarious work —uncertain and unpredictable employment that shifts risk from employers to workers— has spread beyond the margins of the labour market to reach growing portions of the workforce (Kalleberg, 2011), and is not reduced to income insecurity, but entails the absence of the occupational identity, social rights and temporal stability that characterised the standard employment relationship (Standing, 2014). These transformations matter for the welfare state because its institutions were designed around that formal relationship, so that those who depart from it tend to maintain a weaker and more unequal link with the protection system (Emmenegger et al., 2012; Schwander and Häusermann, 2013). This structural position in the labour market shapes that material link, and also conditions attitudes towards inequality and redistribution (Lindh and McCall, 2020), an effect especially visible in contexts of marked commodification such as the Chilean one (Pérez-Ahumada et al., 2026).

Type of employment structures that relationship directly. Workers in formal waged employment contribute through registered contributions and accumulate rights in a legible way, which makes the relationship between what they contribute and what they receive traceable. Workers in non-formal employment face a more opaque and often less favourable relationship, since the self-employed tend to pay higher net contributions and remain excluded from unemployment insurance, while temporary workers accumulate interrupted contribution records that reduce their future benefits (Marx, 2014; Rueda, 2007). This institutional distance between insiders and outsiders in the labour market creates conditions for the latter to perceive that the system was not designed for people in their situation, which may translate into a less favourable assessment of the justice of the fiscal exchange (Schwander and Häusermann, 2013).

Platform-mediated work constitutes a particularly acute form of non-formal employment. Algorithmic intermediation, the classification of workers as independent contractors and the fragmentation of tasks place these workers largely outside the formal architecture of social insurance (Vallas and Schor, 2020; Wood et al., 2019). Several studies have shown that platform workers combine nominal autonomy with a high degree of external control and a fragmented or non-existent social protection (Behrendt et al., 2019; Schor, 2020), a pattern that evidence for Latin America has documented in platform-mediated delivery, where classification as independent contractors shifts risk onto workers and leaves them outside social security (Gutiérrez Crocco and Atzeni, 2022). The European directive on platform work responds to this situation by introducing a legal presumption of employment and rules on algorithmic management (?). This structural position exposes these workers to a lack of protection that leads one to expect a comparatively lower perception of the justice of their relationship with the welfare state. These considerations give rise to the first hypothesis:

H1: Workers in non-formal employment —platform work and self-employment— will perceive lower redistributive justice than workers in formal waged employment.

1.3 Job insecurity

Beyond type of employment, the level of job insecurity experienced by workers constitutes a distinct dimension of vulnerability. Job insecurity is defined as the subjective assessment of the likelihood of losing one's own job or self-employment income in the short term, with the chronic uncertainty and anticipatory anxiety this entails (De Witte, 2005; Sverke et al., 2002). Unlike objective precarity, it is a perceived state that can also affect formally protected workers and whose effects on behaviour and attitudes are widely documented (Anderson and Pontusson, 2007; Chung and Van Oorschot, 2011).

From the perspective of redistributive justice, job insecurity raises what is at stake in the relationship between contributions and benefits. The literature on risk and redistribution has shown that exposure to insecurity increases support for social protection (Cusack et al., 2006; Iversen and Soskice, 2001; Rehm, 2009). The relationship with perceived redistributive justice may, however, operate in a different direction: workers who anticipate losing their job assess with greater scrutiny what they would receive from the state in that scenario, and when that expectation is not accompanied by confidence in the protective capacity of the system, they are likely to perceive the exchange as less just (Marx, 2014). The second hypothesis is thus proposed:

H2: Greater perceived job insecurity will be associated with a lower perception of redistributive justice.

1.4 Perceived technological change

The rise of digital technologies has introduced an additional source of occupational vulnerability, distinct from conventional job insecurity. Estimates of the proportion of jobs susceptible to automation vary widely, but even the most conservative ones anticipate significant changes in the content of tasks and in the viability of numerous occupations (Arntz et al., 2016; Autor, 2015; Bustelo et al., 2020; Frey and Osborne, 2017). What matters for welfare attitudes is not the objective magnitude of that process, but the way in which workers anticipate its effects on their own job (Gallego and Kurer, 2022). That anticipation comprises both the perception of a displacement risk (the probability of losing the job to technology) and the perception of a benefit (the probability that technology will improve the quality of work).

1.4.1 Perception of technological displacement risk

On the one hand, technological change refers to the perception of technological displacement risk, that is, the probability that one's own job will be replaced by a robot or by artificial intelligence, substituted by a provider offering a similar service through a platform, or rendered unviable by the obsolescence of one's own digital skills. Research has shown that the fear of automation is distributed unevenly across occupations and social groups and that it has measurable political and attitudinal consequences (Dekker et al., 2017; Im et al., 2019; Kurer, 2020). The literature on risk and redistribution has robustly established that perceived exposure to technological risk increases the demand for social protection (Busemeyer and Sahm, 2022; Iversen and Soskice, 2001; Rehm, 2009; Thewissen and Rueda, 2019). Following that logic,

workers who perceive their job as threatened by technology hold greater expectations of protection and, when contrasting these with what they actually receive, are more likely to assess their exchange with the welfare state as insufficient (Marx, 2014). The third hypothesis is thus derived:

H3: Workers who perceive a higher probability of being displaced by automation, platform competition or the obsolescence of their skills will report a lower perception of distributive justice.

1.4.2 Perception of technological benefit

On the other hand, technological change refers to the perception of technological benefit, which addresses the probability that technology will make working hours more compatible with private life, reduce the dangerousness or physical demands of work, or lessen its monotony and mental load. This enabling dimension has received much less attention than its threatening counterpart, even though workers' orientation towards technology is not solely negative (Autor, 2015; Brougham and Haar, 2018). Unlike displacement risk, perceiving technology as an improvement in working conditions implies lower exposure to risk and greater optimism about one's occupational trajectory. To the extent that the assessment of the exchange with the welfare state reflects the individual's position of economic security (Rehm, 2009), this positive orientation can be expected to be associated with a more favourable perception of redistributive justice. The fourth hypothesis follows from this:

H4: Workers who perceive technology as enabling —reducing physical demands, improving the balance between work and private life or making work less stressful or monotonous— will perceive greater redistributive justice.

1.5 Perceived deservingness of others

Perceptions of redistributive justice do not depend solely on structural position, but also on the normative frameworks through which individuals assess who and what deserves to receive from the state. Deservingness theory holds that people direct their solidarity towards the groups they consider deserving and withdraw it from those they judge undeserving, on the basis of criteria such as control over one's own situation, attitude, reciprocity, identity and need (Petersen, 2012; Van Oorschot, 2000). In strongly commodified contexts, meritocratic and market-justice beliefs reinforce the tendency to consider undeserving those who are perceived not to contribute enough (Castillo et al., 2025). These judgements about the deservingness of others are analytically distinct from the judgement about the justice of one's own relationship with the system: a person may consider themselves a contributor who does not receive their just share and, at the same time, judge that others receive benefits they do not deserve. Both assessments are, however, part of the same moral economy of welfare, and they can be expected to be connected (Mau, 2014; Van Oorschot et al., 2017).

The connection between the two judgements operates through the norm of reciprocity. The resources that an individual contributes appear to sustain those who do not fulfil their part, which erodes the sense that the system treats them in a just way (Cavallé, 2025; Reeskens and Van Oorschot, 2013). Comparative

research has shown that deservingness perceptions robustly structure support for the welfare state and that the control criterion occupies a central place in those judgements ([Laenen, 2020](#); [Van Oorschot, 2006](#)). It can therefore be expected that those who perceive greater abuse of the system by others will assess their own relationship with it as less just. The fifth hypothesis is proposed:

H5: Workers who perceive that many people receive public benefits without deserving them will report a lower perception of redistributive justice.

1.6 Welfare regimes and institutional context

Individual perceptions of redistributive justice are formed in institutional contexts that vary systematically across welfare regimes ([Arts and Gelissen, 2002](#); [Esping-Andersen, 1993](#)). Esping-Andersen (1993) 's classic typology distinguishes three worlds of welfare capitalism according to how they organise the relationship between state, market and family in the provision of social protection. In social democratic regimes (mainly Nordic countries), protection is comprehensive and universal, and redistribution constitutes a central expression of social solidarity sustained by universalist institutions ([Korpi and Palme, 1998](#)). In liberal regimes (mainly Anglo-Saxon countries and, for example, Chile as a case of a commodified welfare state in Latin America), protection is residual and targeted, is organised around market participation and is politically more contested Pérez-Ahuamda (2023). In conservative-corporatist regimes (continental Europe), rights are strongly tied to employment status, which preserves status differences and links protection to the employment trajectory ([Ferrera, 1996](#)).

Alongside institutional design, macroeconomic factors bear on welfare attitudes: income inequality is associated with perceptions of the justice of the system, although the direction of that relationship is a matter of debate ([Finseraas, 2009](#); [Schmidt-Catran, 2016](#)), and the level of economic development conditions both the fiscal capacity of the state and citizens' expectations regarding social protection ([Blekesaune, 2003](#)). Taken together, the perception of redistributive justice can be expected to be, on average, higher in social democratic regimes, where protection is more comprehensive and universal, than in liberal and conservative regimes ([Jæger, 2006](#); [Larsen, 2008](#); [Svallfors, 1997](#)). Hence the sixth hypothesis:

H6: On average, workers in social democratic regimes will perceive higher redistributive justice than workers in liberal and conservative regimes.

The institutional context not only shifts the average level of perceptions, but may moderate the effect of individual predictors. The institutional distance between workers in non-formal employment and the protection system is greater in liberal and conservative regimes than in social democratic ones, which are universalist in character ([Ferrera, 1996](#); [Schwander and Häusermann, 2013](#)). It can therefore be expected that the negative effect of labour market position on perceived redistributive justice will be more pronounced in the former:

H7: The negative relationship between non-standard employment (platform work and self-employment) and perceived redistributive justice will be moderated by the welfare regime.

An analogous expectation can be formulated for the perception of technological risk. In universalist regimes, protection against the risks associated with digitalisation is more robust and less dependent on the individual employment trajectory, which could cushion the effect of perceived displacement risk on the assessment of the fiscal exchange (Busemeyer and Sahm, 2022; Fan et al., 2024; Gallego and Kurer, 2022):

H8: The negative effect of the perception of technological displacement risk on the perception of redistributive justice will be moderated by the welfare regime.

Finally, the salience of deservingness judgements varies according to institutional design. In universalist regimes, where benefits are conceived as general rights rather than as targeted assistance, the distinctions between deserving and undeserving tend to be less pronounced than in residual regimes, organised around means testing (Larsen, 2008; Van Oorschot et al., 2017). It can therefore be expected that the effect of the perceived deservingness of others on the justice of one's own exchange will be stronger in liberal and conservative regimes:

H9: The negative effect of the perceived deservingness of others on the perception of redistributive justice will be moderated by the welfare regime.

2 Data, variables and methods

2.1 Data

This study uses data from the Risks That Matter (RTM) survey of the OECD, a cross-national public opinion survey applied in 27 member countries of the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. The most recent wave (2024) is used, which includes more than 40,000 people across 27 OECD countries: Australia, Austria, Belgium, Canada, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, the Czech Republic, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, Ireland, Israel, Italy, Japan, Korea, Lithuania, Mexico, the Netherlands, New Zealand, Poland, Portugal and the United States. The survey collects nationally representative data on adults aged between 18 and 64, using stratified sampling with post-stratification weights calibrated by age, sex, region and educational level. The 2024 wave is especially relevant for this study because it captures attitudes in the period following the COVID-19 pandemic, an episode that dramatically accelerated the digitalisation of work, expanded platform employment and exposed the cracks in the social insurance systems of the OECD countries.

2.2 Variables

The dependent variable is the perception of redistributive justice, measured by the item: “I feel that I receive a fair share of public benefits, given the taxes and social contributions that I pay and/or have paid in the past”, answered on a five-point Likert scale ranging from strongly disagree to strongly agree. This item captures the person’s evaluative judgement of the justice of the exchange with the state and is treated as an ordinal variable in all the analyses.

Three sets of independent variables constitute the core of the analysis. The first concerns labour market position and job insecurity. Type of employment is operationalised as a three-category variable distinguishing formal waged employment (permanent or long-term dependent employment), platform work (work mediated by digital platforms) and self-employment. Job insecurity is measured by the item: “How likely do you think it is that you could lose your job or your self-employment income in the next 12 months?”, with response categories ranging from very unlikely to very likely. This item captures the subjective, anticipatory dimension of precarity: workers’ sense of how exposed they are to income loss in the short term.

The second set of variables captures the perception of technological change with respect to one’s own job. These variables are measured through a battery that asks: “How likely do you think it is that the following will happen in your job (or job opportunities) in the next five years?”, with items rated on a four-point probability scale. The battery includes four displacement items—the likelihood that the job will be replaced by a robot, that it will be replaced by an artificial intelligence tool such as ChatGPT, and that it will be replaced by a person offering a similar service through an internet platform, and the likelihood of losing the job through not being sufficiently technologically skilled—and three benefit items—that technology will make working hours more compatible with private life, that it will make work less dangerous or physically demanding, and that it will make it less boring, repetitive, stressful or mentally demanding. However, the exploratory factor analysis carried out on these seven items yields a three-factor structure: the three displacement items load on a first factor; the three benefit items load on a second factor; and the skill obsolescence item separates from both, so that it is retained as a single indicator, capturing an internal element of risk perception, distinct from the other two factors, which are considered external elements. Following the usual practice in constructing composite indices from attitudinal batteries, two scales are built—Technological Displacement Risk (the average of the three displacement items) and Perceived Technological Benefit (the average of the three benefit items)—and Perceived Skill Obsolescence is used as a single item. In all cases, higher values indicate a greater perception of the corresponding risk or benefit.

The third set of independent variables concerns the perceived deservingness of others, operationalised through the item that measures the degree of agreement with the statement «Many people receive public benefits without deserving them», rated on a five-point scale (1 = strongly disagree to 5 = strongly agree). Unlike the dependent variable, which captures the individual’s judgement of the justice of their own relationship with the system, this item captures their judgement of the deservingness of other beneficiaries, a central distinction in the literature on deservingness (Van Oorschot, 2000, 2006). Higher values indicate a more widespread perception of undue deservingness on the part of third parties.

The welfare regime is operationalised as a three-category variable (social democratic, liberal, conservative-corporatist) following Bambra (2007) and Fenger (2006). To classify the countries of southern Europe and of central and eastern Europe present in the sample, the extensions of Ferrera (1996), Fenger (2006) and Aidukaite (2011) are followed, which document both the initial specificity of the post-socialist regimes and their progressive convergence towards the continental types after two decades of transition. On that basis, and given the small number of countries per category, the study adopts a three-regime classification—social democratic, liberal and conservative-corporatist—, in which the countries of southern Europe and of central and eastern Europe are integrated into the conservative category, while the Baltic states, characterised by a more liberal orientation of their post-socialist reforms, are incorporated into the liberal regime (Aidukaite, 2011).

All the models include a set of control variables that have been shown to be associated with attitudes towards the welfare state and perceived redistributive justice: sex, age, educational level (operationalised as the highest level of studies completed) and income decile (self-reported position in the national income distribution).

A summary of these variables and their main descriptive statistics is available in Table 1

Table 1: Main descriptive statistics

Label	Stats / Values	Freqs (% of Valid)	Valid
Redistributive justice	1. Strongly disagree	3506 (18.3%)	19169 (100.0%)
	2. Disagree	4651 (24.3%)	
	3. Neither agree nor disagree	5466 (28.5%)	
	4. Agree	4162 (21.7%)	
	5. Strongly agree	1384 (7.2%)	
Sex	1. Man	All NA's	0
	2. Woman		(0.0%)
Age group	1. 18-24	All NA's	0
	2. 25-34		(0.0%)
	3. 35-44		
	4. 45-54		
	5. 55-64		
Educational level	1. Low	All NA's	0
	2. Medium		(0.0%)
	3. High		

Label	Stats / Values	Freqs (% of Valid)	Valid
Equivalised disposable household income decile (2023)	Mean (sd) : 4.9 (2.9) min < med < max: 1 < 5 < 10 IQR (CV) : 5 (0.6)	1 : 3288 (17.2%) 2 : 1797 (9.4%) 3 : 1723 (9.0%) 4 : 2587 (13.5%) 5 : 2273 (11.9%) 6 : 1777 (9.3%) 7 : 1447 (7.5%) 8 : 1401 (7.3%) 9 : 1272 (6.6%) 10 : 1604 (8.4%)	19169 (100.0%)
Self-employment worker	1. No 2. Yes	All NA's	0 (0.0%)
Platform worker	1. No 2. Yes	All NA's	0 (0.0%)
Lose job	1. Not at all concerned 2. Not so concerned 3. Somewhat concerned 4. Very concerned	2867 (15.0%) 5351 (27.9%) 5920 (30.9%) 5031 (26.2%)	19169 (100.0%)
Technological displacement	Mean (sd) : 2.1 (0.9) min < med < max: 1 < 2 < 4 IQR (CV) : 1.7 (0.4)	13 distinct values	19169 (100.0%)
Perceived technological benefit	Mean (sd) : 2.6 (0.8) min < med < max: 1 < 2.7 < 4 IQR (CV) : 1 (0.3)	13 distinct values	19169 (100.0%)
Lose job due skills	1. Very unlikely 2. Unlikely 3. Likely 4. Very likely	6218 (32.4%) 6595 (34.4%) 4546 (23.7%) 1810 (9.4%)	19169 (100.0%)
Deservingness of others	1. Strongly disagree 2. Disagree 3. Neither agree nor disagree 4. Agree 5. Strongly agree	611 (3.2%) 1683 (8.8%) 4299 (22.4%) 6504 (33.9%) 6072 (31.7%)	19169 (100.0%)
Welfare regime	1. Liberal 2. Social-democratic 3. Conservative	6397 (33.4%) 2888 (15.1%) 9884 (51.6%)	19169 (100.0%)

2.3 Methods

Multilevel ordinal logistic regression models with individuals nested in countries are used to examine the relationship between labour market position, the perception of technological risk or benefit, the deservingness of others and the perception of redistributive justice across different national contexts. This approach makes it possible to account for the hierarchical structure of the comparative data and to decompose the variance of the outcome between individual factors and country characteristics (Hox et al., 2017; Snijders and Bosker, 2012). Random intercepts are estimated for each country to control heterogeneity at the macro level. The models are estimated sequentially: a model including if the workers are self-employed or platform-worker (Model 1), a second model adding job insecurity (Model 2), a third model incorporating the perception of technological risk and benefit (Model 3), a fourth model adding the perception of the deservingness of others (Model 4), a fifth model incorporating the type of welfare regime (Model 5), and a sixth model adding the control variables (Model 6).

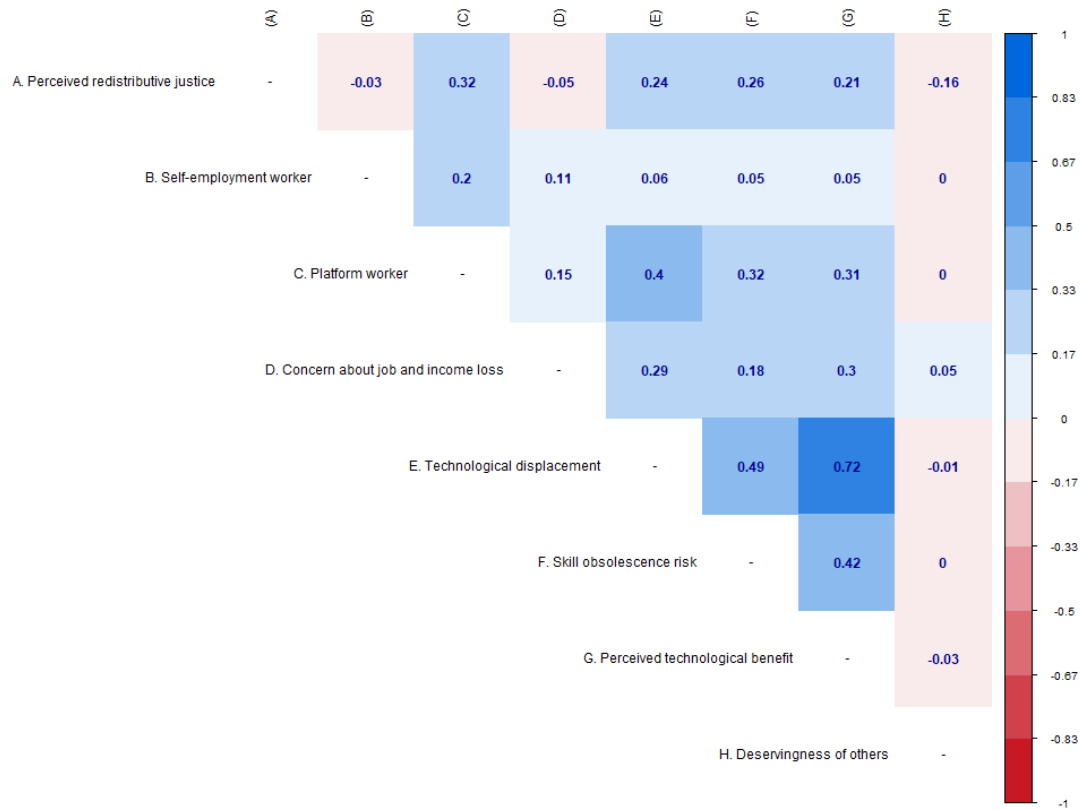
In a seven model, interaction terms between the labour market predictors are introduced (Model 7). In the next models, the type of welfare regime are introduced to test the rest of moderation hypotheses (Models 8 to models 12). All the analyses use the individual survey weights provided by the OECD, and standard errors are clustered by country. The models are estimated with the `clmm` function of the `ordinal` package in R.

3 Analysis

Figure 2 presents a correlation matrix of the main variables analyzed. In this matrix, the correlations vary between low and moderate negative and positive values. The main correlation effects are between perceived redistributive justice and being a platform worker ($r=0,32$, $p<0,001$), the perceived technological displacement ($r=0,24$, $p<0,001$), the skill obsolescence risk ($r=0,26$, $p<0,001$), and the perceived technological benefit ($r=0,21$, $p<0,001$) which are positive and moderated effects. In other sence, the deservingness of others has a negative and moderated effect ($r=0,16$, $p<0,01$).

Regarding the independent variables, the main correlation effects are between the concern about job and income loss and being a platform worker ($r=0,15$, $p<0,001$), and with the perceived of technological change variables. Between this this three last variables, the correlations effects are positive and significant, contrary to the initial intuitions.

Figure 2: Correlation matrix of the main variables



Source: own elaboration with data from OECD risk that matter survey 2024

3.1 Multilevel ordinal logistic regression models

Cumulative-link mixed models were fitted for perceived redistributive justice, with a random intercept for country. Note that ordinal package reports the number of observations as the sum of the sampling weights rather than the count of cases (Haubo and Christensen, 2018); the models were therefore estimated on 19,169 respondents nested in 27 countries (weighted N = 16,872). Coefficients are cumulative log-odds: a positive value indicates greater odds of reporting a higher category of perceived redistributive justice.

Table 2 follows a block-building logic — employment status (Model 1), economic insecurity (Model 2), the technological-perception battery (Model 3), deservingness of others (Model 4) and welfare regime (Model 5) — with sociodemographic controls (sex, age, income and education) entered only in Model 6. Across the sequence the country-level variance declines from 0.235 to 0.193 and the BIC from 50,264.9 to 48,616.2, indicating improved fit as substantive predictors are added.

Table 2: Multilevel models for retributive preferences

Table 3

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
self-employed worker (ref. No)	−0.059 (0.039)	−0.057 (0.039)	−0.057 (0.039)	−0.068 (0.039)	−0.068 (0.039)	−0.069 (0.039)
Platform worker (ref. No)	1.174*** (0.050)	1.189*** (0.050)	0.828*** (0.051)	0.844*** (0.051)	0.843*** (0.051)	0.780*** (0.051)
Concern about job and income loss		−0.054*** (0.014)	−0.180*** (0.015)	−0.175*** (0.015)	−0.176*** (0.015)	−0.166*** (0.015)
Technological displacement			0.265*** (0.023)	0.261*** (0.023)	0.261*** (0.023)	0.237*** (0.024)
Skill obsolescence risk			0.126*** (0.020)	0.123*** (0.020)	0.123*** (0.020)	0.126*** (0.020)
Perceived technological benefit			0.453*** (0.021)	0.456*** (0.021)	0.456*** (0.021)	0.431*** (0.022)
Deservingness of others				−0.181*** (0.014)	−0.181*** (0.014)	−0.177*** (0.014)
Welfare regime (Ref.= Liberal)						
Social-democratic					0.408 (0.267)	0.395 (0.267)
Conservative					−0.138 (0.190)	−0.126 (0.190)
BIC	50264.921	50260.479	48843.271	48682.213	48697.344	48616.180
Numb. obs.	16872	16872	16872	16872	16872	16872
Groups (Country)	27	27	27	27	27	27
Variance: Country: (Intercept)	0.235	0.227	0.244	0.227	0.192	0.193

Note: Cells contain regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$. Model 6 is controlled by sex, age and income with significant effects and education with no

Platform work is the strongest and most stable predictor. In Model 1 its coefficient is 1.174 ($p < 0.001$; OR ≈ 3.2); it attenuates as the technological and deservingness blocks enter but remains large in the fully adjusted Model 6 (0.780, $p < 0.001$; OR ≈ 2.2), so platform workers have roughly twice the odds of expressing higher perceived redistributive justice. Self-employment is non-significant throughout (≈ -0.06). Concern about job and income loss is negative and strengthens once technological perceptions are held constant, moving from -0.054 in Model 2 to -0.166 in Model 6 ($p < 0.001$).

The technological-perception battery (from Model 3) is uniformly positive. Perceived technological benefit carries the largest effect (≈ 0.43 – 0.46 , $p < 0.001$), followed by technological displacement (≈ 0.24 – 0.27 , $p < 0.001$) and skill-obsolescence risk (≈ 0.12 , $p < 0.001$). The positive sign on technological displacement runs counter to the hypothesised direction, a point developed further in the discussion. Deservingness of others (Model 4) is negative and stable (≈ -0.18 , $p < 0.001$). Welfare regime, entered as a main effect in Model 5, is not significant: relative to liberal regimes, neither the social-democratic (≈ 0.40) nor the conservative (≈ -0.13) contrast reaches conventional thresholds. The addition of controls in Model 6 leaves this individual-level structure essentially unchanged.

Table 4 takes the fully adjusted specification and introduces one interaction at a time: self-employed $\times$ platform (Model 7), followed by the cross-level products of welfare regime with self-employment (Model 8), platform work (Model 9), economic insecurity (Model 10), technological displacement (Model 11) and deservingness (Model 12). The BIC is narrow across these models (48,612.2–48,626.8) and the country variance stable (≈ 0.19). The four regime moderations are displayed in Figure 3a; because emmeans R package (Lenth and Piaskowski, 2017) evaluates the fitted model on the latent scale, the panels show predicted latent propensity rather than category-specific probabilities, which is why each moderation reduces to a single linear panel.

The individual-level interaction is negative —self-employed $\times$ platform = -0.413 ($p < 0.001$)— so the platform effect is weaker among workers who are simultaneously self-employed. The cross-level terms then reveal that the null regime main effects in Table 2 mask substantial moderation. Self-employment matters only in social-democratic regimes ($\times$ social-democratic = -0.400 , $p < 0.01$; $\times$ conservative n.s.), shown in the top-left panel as the steep social-democratic decline against flat liberal and conservative lines. Platform work is positive across all regimes (top right), but its slope is much shallower under social-democratic arrangements ($\times$ social-democratic = -0.607 , $p < 0.001$), where respondents begin from a higher baseline.

The same dampening governs the remaining predictors. Technological displacement is positive in every regime (bottom left) but significantly attenuated relative to liberal regimes ($\times$ social-democratic = -0.214 ; $\times$ conservative = -0.138 ; both $p < 0.001$). Deservingness is negative throughout (bottom right), with the steepest slope in conservative regimes ($\times$ conservative = -0.090 , $p < 0.01$) and a non-significant social-democratic interaction. Economic insecurity interacts significantly only with the conservative contrast (-0.120 , $p < 0.001$). Once these interactions are specified, the social-democratic main effect becomes significant in the displacement and deservingness models (0.843, $p < 0.01$; 0.638, $p < 0.05$), where it was null in Table 2.

Table 4: Interaction multilevel models for retributive preferences

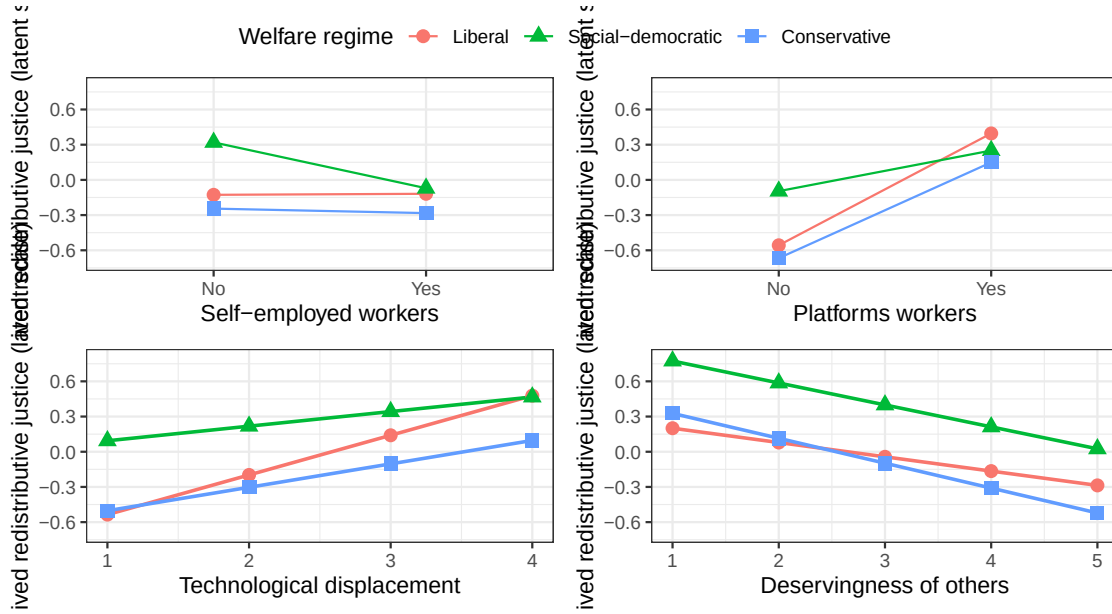
Table 5

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Self-employed worker (ref. No)	−0.018 (0.042)	0.009 (0.069)	−0.071 (0.039)	−0.068 (0.039)	−0.071 (0.039)	−0.071 (0.039)
Platform worker (ref. No)	0.877*** (0.058)	0.781*** (0.051)	0.953*** (0.079)	0.775*** (0.051)	0.777*** (0.051)	0.779*** (0.051)
Concern about job and income loss	−0.167*** (0.015)	−0.166*** (0.015)	−0.165*** (0.015)	−0.098*** (0.025)	−0.165*** (0.015)	−0.165*** (0.015)
Technological displacement	0.237*** (0.024)	0.238*** (0.024)	0.236*** (0.024)	0.238*** (0.024)	0.338*** (0.032)	0.236*** (0.024)
Deservingness of others	−0.176*** (0.014)	−0.177*** (0.014)	−0.177*** (0.014)	−0.177*** (0.014)	−0.178*** (0.014)	−0.122*** (0.024)
Social-democratic	0.394 (0.267)	0.447 (0.270)	0.461 (0.268)	0.533 (0.290)	0.843** (0.286)	0.638* (0.309)
Conservative	−0.128 (0.190)	−0.117 (0.192)	−0.110 (0.191)	0.201 (0.209)	0.171 (0.206)	0.217 (0.223)
Self-employed X Platform worker	−0.413*** (0.116)					
Self-employed X Social-democratic		−0.400** (0.128)				
Self-employed X Conservative		−0.047 (0.087)				
Platform worker X Social-democratic			−0.607*** (0.135)			
Platform worker X Conservative			−0.137 (0.109)			
Job and income loss X Social-democratic				−0.047 (0.044)		
Job and income loss X Conservative				−0.120*** (0.032)		
Technological displacement X Social-democratic					−0.214*** (0.049)	
Technological displacement X Conservative					−0.138*** (0.037)	
Deservingness X Social-democratic						−0.065 (0.041)
Deservingness X Conservative						−0.090** (0.031)
BIC	48613.219	48625.127	48615.167	48621.208	48612.196	48626.846
Numb. obs.	16872	16872	16872	16872	16872	16872
Groups (Country)	27	27	27	27	27	27
Variance: Country: (Intercept)	0.193	0.196	0.193	0.193	0.192	0.194

Note: Cells contain regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$. All models are controlled by sex, age and income with significant effects and education with

A consistent pattern emerges: across all four panels the social-democratic line is the flattest, and every regime interaction with an individual-level predictor is negative. Substantively, perceptions of redistributive justice in social-democratic regimes appear less responsive to individual labour-market position and technological perceptions than under liberal arrangements, consistent with the view that encompassing welfare institutions decouple distributive attitudes from individual exposure.

Figure 3: Estimated latent propensity for perceived redistributive justice, by selected predictors across welfare regimes



(a) Source: own elaboration with data from the OECD, Risks That Matter survey 2024.

4 Discussion

This article asked whether the perceived justice of the fiscal exchange between citizens and the state is anchored in labour-market position and in how workers anticipate technological change, and whether welfare institutions condition that relationship. The results lend qualified support to the reciprocity framework that motivated the analysis, but their main interest lies where they depart from the risk-and-redistribution tradition from which the hypotheses were drawn. Three individual-level expectations held: perceived job insecurity and the perception that others receive undeserved benefits both depressed perceived redistributive justice (H2, H5), while perceiving technology as enabling raised it (H4) and was the strongest individual predictor. Two did not: non-standard employment was not associated with lower perceived redistributive justice, and platform workers reported it more strongly (H1); and perceived technological displacement risk, expected to erode justice, instead increased it (H3). The moderation analyses, finally, disclosed an institutional patterning that the null average differences between regimes had obscured.

The confirmed hypotheses support the moral-economy reading on which the study rests. Workers who anticipate losing their job or income within the year judge the exchange as less just (H2), and those

who perceive others as drawing unearned benefits extend that judgement to their own relationship with the system (H5), consistent with the view that lateral deservingness assessments and self-referential justice belong to a single moral economy of welfare (Mau, 2014; Van Oorschot, 2006). That the enabling dimension of technology carries the largest effect (H4) is a reminder that workers' orientation towards technology is not solely defensive, and that its optimistic pole, long neglected relative to its threatening counterpart, matters for welfare attitudes (Autor, 2015; Brougham and Haar, 2018).

Self-employment was unrelated to perceived redistributive justice throughout, which is unsurprising given a category ranging from established professionals to precarious own-account workers whose contrasting ties to the protection system plausibly offset one another. The reversal for platform work — roughly twice the odds of higher perceived justice ($OR \approx 2.2$) — admits two readings. Compositionally, self-reported platform work in OECD samples is heterogeneous, capturing supplementary and intermittent earners alongside the platform-dependent (Schor, 2020; Vallas and Schor, 2020); the negative self-employed $\times$ platform interaction localises the effect among workers most likely to combine platform earnings with other employment. Substantively, perceived redistributive justice is a judgement of proportionality, not of absolute generosity: workers loosely attached to the contributory system contribute and expect little, so a thin return reads as proportionate, whereas formal employees with visible contributions and legible entitlements may by the same token feel short-changed (Schwander and Häusermann, 2013).

The positive association between perceived technological displacement risk and perceived redistributive justice (H3), echoed by perceived skill obsolescence, is the more consequential departure, and its failure to follow a strong prior is itself informative. Conceptually, the dependent variable is an evaluation of the justice of one's own exchange, not a demand for redistribution. The literature behind H3 establishes that perceived risk raises the demand for protection (Busemeyer and Sahm, 2022; Iversen and Soskice, 2001; Thewissen and Rueda, 2019), but wanting more redistribution and judging the present exchange as just are analytically distinct and need not move together; a worker may want the state to do more in the face of automation while still considering that, given what they pay, they receive a just share. The reversal therefore partly reflects measuring a different attitudinal object, and confirms the preferences–perceptions distinction the article insists on (Roosma et al., 2016). Compositionally, the diffusion of generative artificial intelligence has extended perceived exposure into formal, higher-skill and digitally engaged workers (Gallego and Kurer, 2022) — those with the most continuous link to the contributory system — so that perceived risk co-travels with relative inclusion rather than marginality.

The moderation evidence favours this reading. Were the positive coefficient produced by institutional reassurance, it should be largest where protection is most encompassing; instead it is steepest in liberal regimes and significantly attenuated in social-democratic and conservative ones (H8). A temporal contrast reinforces the point: the displacement battery is prospective and abstract, asking about a five-year horizon, whereas the job-insecurity item that behaves as predicted (H2) concerns concrete income loss within twelve months. Near-term, tangible insecurity erodes justice; distant technological prognostication does not, and may instead index a reflective engagement with the future of work bound up with other favourable dispositions (Dekker et al., 2017; Kurer, 2020). A measurement caveat sharpens rather than dissolves this: displacement and benefit are positively correlated with each other and with the outcome, and although the

factor analysis separates them, the shared sign suggests a common component of engagement with the technological frame, which future instrumentation should separate from valence.

The comparative results recast the regime argument. Regime type did not order perceived redistributive justice as a main effect (H6), consistent with the heterogeneity already visible in Figure 1a and at odds with the classic regime hypothesis (Jæger, 2006; Svallfors, 1997). Across all four moderation panels the social-democratic slope is the flattest and every regime interaction is negative: the employment effect is confined to social-democratic regimes (H7), the displacement effect is dampened in both non-liberal regimes (H8), and the deservingness effect is steepest in conservative regimes and indistinguishable between liberal and social-democratic ones (H9), only partly matching the universalist–residual expectation. The unifying reading is that universalist institutions decouple perceived redistributive justice from individual labour-market exposure, whereas residual, market-tied arrangements bind the two together (Larsen, 2008; Rothstein, 1998). This refines the institutional-logic tradition: regimes act less by raising the level of satisfaction than by governing how far it fragments along individual lines, a dynamic especially salient in highly commodified contexts such as the Chilean one (Emmenegger et al., 2012; Pérez-Ahumada et al., 2026).

5 Conclusion

Drawing on the 2024 wave of the OECD Risks That Matter survey across 27 countries, this article has shown that the perceived redistributive justice of the fiscal exchange with the welfare state is anchored in the experience of work, though not in the manner the risk-and-redistribution tradition would predict. Concrete employment insecurity and the perception that others receive undeserved benefits erode perceived justice, and perceiving technology as enabling enhances it; but non-standard employment does not depress justice (platform workers report it more strongly) and perceived technological displacement risk raises rather than lowers it. Above all, universalist welfare institutions appear to decouple perceived redistributive justice from individual labour-market position and technological perception, while residual arrangements tie them tightly together.

Two implications for the sociology of welfare attitudes follow. First, perceptions and preferences must be kept analytically apart: the same exposure that raises the demand for redistribution may leave the evaluation of one’s own exchange unchanged or even more favourable, so findings established for one attitudinal object cannot be transposed to the other (Roosma et al., 2016). The second is that the comparative purchase of welfare-regime theory on these attitudes lies less in differences of level than in differences of structuring: regimes shape how strongly individual circumstances translate into judgements of justice. Reframing the regime effect as one of decoupling rather than elevation offers a more accurate account of why, in some institutional settings but not others, the legitimacy of the welfare state fragments along the contours of the labour market.

These conclusions are bounded by the design. The data are cross-sectional, so the analysis identifies associations rather than causal effects, and reverse causation is plausible: those who already regard their exchange with the state as just may evaluate technological change more benignly, rather than the reverse.

The principal independent variables of theoretical interest rest on single items or short scales, and the platform and self-employment categories are internally heterogeneous, conflating distinct relationships with the protection system under a common label (Vallas and Schor, 2020). The positive manifold among the technological-perception items signals that the battery does not fully separate the valence of a perception from engagement with technological change as a frame. At the macro level, 27 countries afford limited power for cross-level interactions and place a heavy burden on the regime classification, whose treatment of the post-socialist and southern European cases, while defensible, remains contestable (Aidukaite, 2011; Ferrera, 1996).

These limitations mark out an agenda. Panel data would allow the temporal ordering of technological perception and perceived redistributive justice to be established and reverse causation to be assessed directly. Instrumentation that separates concrete from prospective technological risk, and the valence of a perception from the salience of technological change, would clarify the mechanisms behind the displacement anomaly; qualitative inquiry into how platform and own-account workers construct the reference points against which they believe that justice would do the same for the platform result. Comparative leverage would be improved by replacing categorical regimes with continuous indicators of decommodification and of active labour-market and social-investment provision, which would also permit a more direct test of whether policy feedback, rather than reassurance, underlies the institutional patterning observed here (Fan et al., 2024; Gallego and Kurer, 2022). Greater attention to within-regime heterogeneity, particularly in the commodified welfare states of Latin America, would test the generalisability of the decoupling thesis beyond the European core (Pérez-Ahumada et al., 2026).

The legitimacy of the welfare state in the digital transition appears to depend less on the objective pace of automation than on whether institutions can prevent perceived redistributive justice from fragmenting along individual labour-market lines. On the evidence presented here, universalist designs are better able to do so. As digitalisation continues to remake the standard employment relationship around which social protection was built (Howcroft et al., 2025), how perceived justice is distributed across the workforce, not only how much redistribution citizens want, is likely to become a central question for the comparative study of welfare legitimacy.

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